

DECISIVE MOMENT

ATTEMPTED COUP, 1981

At 6:30 pm on February 23, 1981, Spain's parliament was seized by 200 soldiers of the Guardia Civil. Under Spain's 1978 constitution King Juan Carlos had handed power to an elected legislature and became a nonruling monarch. This caused animosity within the armed forces, which led to the attempted military coup. But within hours the coup collapsed when the king himself appeared on television, calling for public support for the democratic government.

Fascism's last gasp

Colonel Antonio Tejero (right) fires shots into the air as he announces the coup, telling deputies to await the arrival of a "competent military authority" who never came.



1873–74 A republic is briefly declared.

1874 Constitutional monarchy restored under Alfonso XII.

1881 Trade unions legalized.

1884 Spain acquires Rio de Oro in the Western Sahara.

1886 Death of Alfonso XII; he is succeeded by his son Alfonso XIII.

1898 Defeat in war with US results in loss of Cuba, Puerto Rico, and the Philippines; islands in the western Pacific are transferred to Germany.

1912 Spain acquires protectorate in Morocco.

1914–18 Spain neutral in World War I.

1921 Spanish army routed by Berbers in Spanish Morocco.

1923 Coup by General Primo de Rivera is accepted by King Alfonso XIII. Military dictatorship runs Spain in an increasingly authoritarian way.

1930 Primo de Rivera is dismissed by Alfonso XIII.

1931 Second Republic proclaimed under the radical Miguel Azaña. Alfonso XIII flees Spain. Spain is now split between right-wing nationalists, monarchists, Carlists, a growing Fascist movement based on the Falange Party, and the Roman Catholic Church, and a left wing of republicans, socialists, communists, anarchists, radicals, trade unionists, and Catalan and Basque separatists.

1932 Statute of autonomy granted to Catalonia; it is revoked after the general election the following year.

1932 Government introduces agrarian law to improve wages and working conditions on the land against fierce resistance from traditional landowners.

1933 Center-right coalition wins general election.

1934 Asturias uprising quashed by army.

1936 Civil war begins after Popular Front—a republican coalition—wins elections. Right-wing military uprising against the republic coordinated by General Francisco Franco, who is subsequently appointed leader of the nationalists and invades from Morocco. Germany and Italy support the Nationalists, the USSR supports the Republicans, with individual socialists and communists from across Europe joining the International Brigades. UK and France try to impose an arms ban on both sides.

1937 German Condor Legion bombs ancient Basque capital of Guernica as the Nationalists overrun the Basque country.

1939 Nationalists first capture Barcelona and then Madrid, ending the Civil War, which claims more than 600,000 lives. Franco imposes authoritarian, conservative, and Catholic rule, and crushes all dissent, making his Falange Party the sole legal political party.

1940 Franco meets Hitler, but does not enter World War II.

1946 UN condemns Franco regime.

1948 Spain excluded from the Marshall Plan to rebuild Europe after the war.

1950 UN lifts veto on Spanish membership.

1951 US changes policy toward Spain, now seeing Franco as a bulwark against communism, and begins to provide aid.

1953 Concordat with Vatican. Franco grants US military bases in Spain.

1955 Spain joins UN.

1959 Stabilization Plan is basis for rapid economic growth in the next decade.

1961 Basque separatist group ETA begins violent campaign for independence.

1969 Franco names Juan Carlos, grandson of Alfonso XIII, as his successor.

1973 Basque separatists assassinate prime Minister Carrero Blanco; replaced by Arias Navarro.

1975 Death of Franco: proclamation of King Juan Carlos I.

1976 King appoints Adolfo Suárez as prime minister.

1977 First democratic elections since 1936 are won by Suárez's Democratic Center Union.

1978 New constitution declares Spain a parliamentary monarchy and is approved by a public referendum.

1981 Leopoldo Calvo Sotelo replaces Suárez. King foils attempted fascist coup in the Cortés. Spain joins NATO.

1982 Felipe González wins victory for Spanish Socialist Workers' Party (PSOE).



The Guggenheim

Opened to the public in 1997 and dedicated to modern and contemporary art, the Guggenheim Museum formed part of a large and successful regeneration plan for the northern city of Bilbao.

1986 Spain joins European Community. González wins referendum on keeping Spain in NATO.

1992 Olympic Games held in Barcelona, Expo '92 in Seville; both huge successes.

1996 PSOE loses election; José María Aznar of the Conservative Popular Party (PP) is prime minister. He takes a hard line on Basque separatism and skilfully manages a rapidly improving economy.

1998 Former PSOE minister and two others found guilty of involvement in Basque kidnappings.

1999 The Basque terrorist organization ETA ends ceasefire.

2000 Aznar and PP win general elections.

2001 Conscription is abolished.

2002 Euro introduced.

2004 Islamic terrorists bomb trains in Madrid in retaliation against Spanish support for the US invasion of Iraq: 200 people are killed. The Aznar government loses general election three days later to the PSOE, led by José Luis Zapatero, who pulls Spanish troops out of Iraq.

2005 ETA car bomb explodes in Madrid. The government offers peace talks to ETA about the future of the Basque region. ETA declares a "permanent ceasefire" in 2006 but it is broken the same year by a car bomb at Madrid airport.

2007 More than 22,000 immigrants arrive from West Africa.

2008 Socialists are reelected to Parliament with increased representation.

2009 In Basque regional elections, a non-nationalist regional government is returned for the first time in more than 30 years.

2010 ETA announces a new ceasefire but it is dismissed by the government.

- «110–13 From Republic to Empire
- «174–77 The Ascent of Islam
- «188–91 Medieval Europe
- «224–25 Voyages of Discovery
- «226–27 Isabella of Castile
- «228–29 Columbus Lands in the Caribbean
- «234–35 Spanish Silver
- «262–63 The 30 Years War
- «318–19 Latin America Liberated
- «386–87 Fascism
- «388–89 The Spanish Civil War

Andorra



A tiny, Catalan-speaking country in the Pyrenees bordered by France and Spain.

218 BCE The Andosini, a tribe subdued by the Carthaginian general, Hannibal, are the first recorded inhabitants of the state.